Sample essay prompts

Here are some essay prompts that we've had success with — feel free to use or adapt these or to create your own. The key with essay prompts is to give students freedom to explore some aspect of the topic that they're interested in. This allows them not only to write about something they care about, but also gives them space to critically think and develop a position (instead of being forced into a topic/argument assigned by the teacher).

1 A problem in your community

Write an essay about a problem in your community and how we might solve it. "Community" might refer to your neighborhood, school, grade, city, state, country, age group, race, gender, or any other group you belong to. Your essay can focus on any problems that you see or feel. Use your personal experience and observations to develop your position, and evidence from your own experience to support your ideas. How do you propose we solve this problem?

Your essay should be organized formally, with an introduction, thesis statement, body paragraphs, and a conclusion.

2 The novel you just read

Write a critical essay about [the novel we just read for class]. You can choose any aspect of the novel that interests you. Consider the themes we've discussed, the characters, the settings, or anything you've noticed about the story that you think is worthy of discussion.

Use your observations and opinions to develop your position, and quotations from the book to support your ideas.

Your essay should be organized formally, with an introduction, thesis statement, body paragraphs, and a conclusion.

3 A problem in education

Write a critical essay that discusses a problem in education. Use your personal experience and observations to develop your position, and evidence from your own experience to support your ideas. How do you propose we solve this problem?

Your essay should be organized formally, with an introduction, thesis statement, body paragraphs, and a conclusion.

4 What gives you hope

Write an essay about what gives you hope in the world today. When you look around at the world and all of its complexity, and you look ahead to the future, what gives you hope? You might identify problems that you believe you and your generation can solve, changes or innovations that you look forward to, or people/things that inspire your hope in the face of adversity.

Your essay can include how you define hope, what hope looks like for you personally, or the role hope plays in shaping the state of the world today. You might consider the quote, “If despair creates problems, hope can achieve the impossible.” You may use your personal experiences and observations to develop your stance, and evidence from your own life to support your ideas. In some cases, you may use outside sources to support your ideas.

Your essay should be organized formally, with an introduction, thesis statement, body paragraphs, and a conclusion.